sportsman. I don’t experience things in slow motion, like others. If anything, time goes too quickly for me. Occasionally, though, the game becomes metronomic.

The best personal example of that was in Abu Dhabi, playing Pakistan in October 2015. I batted for 836 minutes, after being in the field for two days, in temperatures that rose to 40 degrees. A weird physiological anomaly, known as anhidrosis, means I don’t sweat, but the air was very hot and still. Conditions were simply unpleasant.

Somehow, I entered another dimension. It was surreal, a 528-ball vigil in a near-deserted stadium. I got to my hundred relatively quickly, but after that was as regular as clockwork, scoring thirty runs a session, until I got out, gently top-edging off-spinner Shoaib Malik to short fine leg for 263 just before the close on the fourth day.

It couldn’t be that straightforward, of course. Replays confirmed it was a no-ball. It was a strange sensation: the body, in the end, succumbed to understandable fatigue but the mind remained rock solid. If I am being honest, I surprised myself. I usually refresh myself after every ball by walking towards square leg to clear the mind, but this felt different.

Mental strength, to use widely applied shorthand to the virtues of sustained self-containment, fascinates across sport. It is a very hard thing to define, but its functionality underpinned a mutually educational visit by the Essex team to Saracens, a rugby club that prides itself on the development of an innovative, performance culture.

These visits are sometimes superficial. The only thing we really took from a similar visit to Ipswich Town FC was an appreciation of how hard the pros kick the ball. Football, I suppose, exists in its own bubble. I’m generalizing a little, but the players weren’t that interested in impressing a bunch of cricketers or sharing insight.

The rugby guys were different. We warmed up with them, playing four-goal football with two balls. It required sharpness, peripheral vision and rapid decision-making, and was hugely enjoyable. We played a bit of touch rugby, shared a fitness session and watched their skill-specific training. They had fun but knew when to work.

They then invited us into their team meeting, where we swapped ideas and examined common experiences. Theirs is a harsh, physically demanding sport, but the best need mental discipline to cope with the